

| By Hasan Zaidi in Quetta |

Hemmed in by three different mountain ranges, Quetta is lush compared to the stark and magnificently barren—almost lunar—landscape beyond the valley. Miles upon miles of brown desert with no vegetation in sight, and mountain after bleak mountain scrunched together with almost no human settlement visible. It hardly seems like the kind of place that has aroused such sharp passions between the Pakistani and Indian establishments and on which is centred the latest diplomatic storm that began last month with a prime ministerial handshake in Egypt's Sharm el-Sheikh. That was when a

AP PHOTO

